

Q You contribute to these projects from the India facility also?

We have some engineers who are part of our contributory groups for these open source and open standards environments.

Q Keeping these open source projects and open standards environments in mind, what kind of skillsets do you look for in the engineers when you take them on board?

There are some basic classical development environments that are pretty much considered as standards, whether it is object oriented coding, the C/C++ or the Java environments. These are being rapidly supplemented by other tool sets and make more sense in the kind of Web scale deployment languages like Ruby and Ruby on Rails. In fact, a whole gamut of open source development environments is used at NetApp in Web scale deployments and initiatives. So in our R&D environments, we look for the classical development skills around traditional languages like C/C++, Java and so on. In addition, we look for core operating system architectural skills, because the storage platform is a fairly comprehensive one that we have developed over the last 20 years into more or less a storage operating system. It provides a kernel—a set of data services on top, which will be the basis for features in our products like SnapShot, Compression, De-Duplication, etc. So familiarity with operating system development is something that would be highly desirable in an environment like NetApp.

“Certifications definitely help.

There are a whole lot of reputed organisations in India that offer certifications. These supplement the curriculum that the colleges teach.

This is an interesting development that helps students improve their profile.”

Q Since it is not such a favourable time for the economy, do you still have plans to hire and grow the workforce?

The economy going through a difficult time is definitely a challenge. It is an opportunity for people to look closely at IT. When we talk to customers who are using our products, we can see two distinct trends that incorporate the economic realities of today. On one hand, there is a whole set of efficiencies that customers are looking to bring in to their IT architecture, whether it is in enterprises, service providers or government. One of the areas that they will be keenly looking at is to optimise the cost. The second aspect that's linked to the first is that given the economic environment, and with enterprises looking to get a bigger share of what is probably a stagnant market, enterprises

and services providers would need to differentiate their products and offerings in the market space to appeal over their competition. So the ability to provide differentiated solutions, the ability to reach products to the market faster, or provide services that appeal to the consumers and end users is something that is very much in the minds of enterprises and service providers.

In a market that is not growing sufficiently, one way to continue with growth is to optimise on cost and another way is to increase revenue by reaching out to more and more consumers and acquiring a higher market share. So enterprises are also focused on reaching out to more customers to respond to the fluctuating conditions.

Over the last 20 years, we have focused on both sides of the picture. We are trying to offer the best of technology, which reflects in the hiring that we continue to do in the areas of focus decided by us. Our technology makes sense to the market place, and therefore we continue to invest in the right skills in areas that we want to focus on to deliver innovation.

Q Do you hire freshers or do you prefer lateral hiring?

We span the entire gamut. NetApp places a lot of emphasis on the culture of the workplace. Our culture is enriched by the diversity of the talent that we have in the company. We believe that each new hire brings something unique and valuable to the company. While we do lateral hiring at NetApp, we have a fairly programmed approach to hiring new graduates from colleges. This happens both in the R&D and sales departments.

Q Do you feel that the certifications in IT add value to one's profile and are helpful in getting professionals hired?

Certifications definitely help. There are a whole lot of reputed organisations in India that offer certifications. These supplement the curriculum that the colleges teach. This is an interesting development that helps students improve their profile. I can remember that during my years as a student, I was completely isolated from what was going on in the development environments around the world. But today, college students have unprecedented access to the general trends in the applications and the platform development space. They have opportunities to participate in and contribute to a wide variety of open source communities even before they start working. If all this can be supplemented by certifications, there's nothing like it. But that is definitely not all. The few important things that are looked for include skills from the technology stand point, the right attitude in terms of innovation—how prepared is the candidate to face the anticipated developments and trends in the technology space, and an attitude that fosters an enterprising initiative, like working with open source communities across the globe. Good coding skills and the correct attitude can get you hired. 